Yellowettes

1. "Que miras?"

She asks me again. I am still in the hallway of my apartment glancing up above the doorframe where there is a stained-glass window I have passed for years without seeing. Yellow glass, uneven and old, with dark metal strips curved into flowers and holding the pains together, catching whatever light manages to reach it. I remember the first time I noticed it I stood there realising this piece of decorative glass had lived in my home, longer than I had, and I had never seen it before. After I did it became impossible not to look.

2. The Seagram Murals, could have been purchased, lit beautifully, placed directly in front of someone, and still have trouble being seen.



3. I remember his robe, okra green and mustard yellow crossed with thin brown stripes. He changed into it when the day was finished and came to sit around the table. It meant he was home. It meant conversation, food, warmth, his particular authority, which somehow managed to coexist with kindness. Memory chooses its own relics.

4. Yellow is the color of belated attention.

5. The sun is approximately 150 million kilometers away. I am told to live with that.

6. This summer, in a notebook I started, meant for art and poetry and science and films and things I was afraid I would otherwise forget, I wrote in yellow crayon: the sun, so abundant with life, leaked of stars, sea and sediment.

There is no better instrument to materialize the grandeur of our sun.

7. If tomorrow were the final sunrise, everyone would wake for it. There would be traffic at five in the morning. People would climb rooftops, people would have tears in their eyes, phones would be held towards the horizon, attempting the impossible task of capturing it. But the sun is scheduled to return, so in the mornings we sleep through it. Perhaps abundance is another form of invisibility.

8. I heard that Van Gogh ate yellow paint, because he thought it would put happiness inside him. As if happiness were a pigment, as if the body were a jar. Much like possessing the evidence of a moment is not the same as living through that moment. All though we think exposure might be a prevalent disappearance. The yellow paint does not stain my red beating heart with happiness and the fading image in my head does not take me back to that afternoon but maybe it tastes better from a distance.



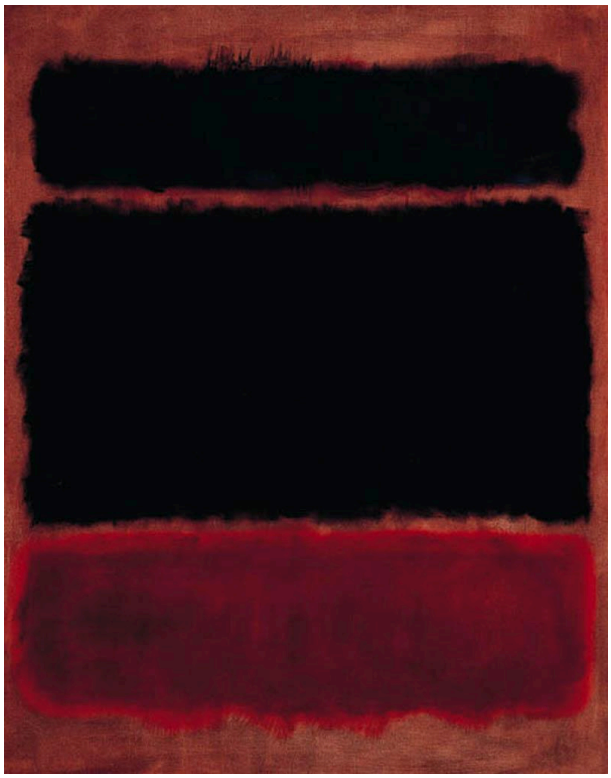
9. like sunlight by the spoonful.

10. Butter Yellow. A colour already named after something we can spread. I understand the appeal. I would like to apply a thin layer of summer to things. My sleeves, my bedroom, the part of the afternoon when I begin to feel inexplicably awful.

11. Cadmium yellow is toxic. Yellow is jaundice. Yellow is infection, Yellow is the outer lines of a bruise. Yellow is warning tape. Yellow is happiness. Yellow is a song that makes me cry.

12. Rothko fears that "The black will swallow the red." Swallow is a bodily word. It gives darkness a stomach. I imagine him watching the edges of his paintings, checking whether anything has been eaten overnight. Perhaps this is what frightens me about forgetting. Nothing leaves all at once. There is just slightly less of it when you return.

13. Colour has an appetite, Black threatens to swallow red, to consume the very thing that makes the canvas feel alive. His fear is of one colour becoming absolute, leaving no other feelings possible. Yet he needs the darkness there. Without it the brightness would have nothing to struggle against. The canvas holds this paradox that seems to consume him, the vitality of a changing world and his fear of what that change will take from him. Of us leaving him behind.



14. Mr.I's loss is much greater than being unable to identify color. Color had been woven into the emotional meaning of ordinary life. Food stops looking appetizing, people stop looking human in the familiar way, even his own reflection feels alien. At first, the color loss becomes a loss of familiarity and emotional connection, the world is still visible but it is no longer inhabitable.

15. I wonder what Mr. I would do it if he got his color vision back. Would he refuse to blink, letting his retinas absorb the wavelengths, eyes open and watering?

16. Yellow is the reflection of the Harkness table in the saturated English room. I wonder whether leaving school will change the colour of the Harkness table in my memory. Whether it will become more golden each year until we appear to have spent our English lessons seated around an enormous ingot. I would like to record its actual shade now, before affection interferes with the evidence.

17. Rothko faces the difficult prospect of becoming history while he is still in the room. Pop Art is arriving with its soup cans and recognizable faces, ordinary things made into instant images. There is something offensive about this soup can after you have spent years trying to get a colored square containing a tragedy. Yet his objections have a personal inconvenience, he belongs to a generation that also displaced another. He can defend the necessity of change right up to the point where it requires him to move.

Ken makes this difficult to ignore. The younger artist has opinions, a future, an increasing ability to disagree. Rothko has helped educate someone who will eventually leave him. It seems an impractical arrangement, although schools do it every year.



18. I am approaching the end of school and beginning to find the whole system a little presumptuous. The Harkness table will be used without me. Someone else will sit where I sat and discover something I have already underlined. The room will continue producing afternoons. have spent years being told to prepare for whatever comes next, but very little time considering how familiar everything here has become.

This is where I understand Rothko's reluctance to let a familiar world change. He has mistaken being central to a world for being necessary to its continuation. But I am also Ken, impatient to leave, wanting a life that had not already been arranged around a timetable. Depending on the hour, I want to stay in this room or find out who I might become outside of it. Growing up appears to require both people, the one who opens the door and the one who would prefer everyone stayed a little longer.

19. My mother used to leave the hallway light on when I went to sleep. It slipped underneath the door in one thin yellow line, the hue of cheap butter and old teeth. I never looked directly at it for very long. The point was simply that it was there. And now it never is.

20. I keep asking colour to do something it cannot quite do; return a person, prolong the present, make the feeling of my memories tangible enough to me that I can hold them. I am beginning to wonder where colour lives. In the object, in the light, in the eye, somewhere further back where the eye's information becomes life? I could probably find out but I prefer not knowing. My grandfather's robe was mustard yellow before I loved him in it. Presumably someone else could have worn it. This seems technically correct and otherwise impossible. I cannot separate the pigment from the person long enough to imagine it belonging to anyone else.

My memory does not only contain yellow, my memory is a kaleidoscope. There was the green in his robe, earthy and okra, and the thin maroon stripes keeping their small, dependable distances. There is the red being closed eyelids when I turn towards the sun, the strange experience of receiving light through myself. Blue fills me up remembering afternoons. White can be clean linen or the hospital ceiling, or the untouched page on which I am supposed to know what I think. I call these colors by their names as though naming them settles anything, but the white of the hospital follows me home, and the white of the page waits.

Rothko fears that black will swallow red. The language gives an inward terror, a physical event. Something is consumed. How much harder to say exactly what threatens us when we feel that the world has changed. Mr. I can still see the objects around him, but without colour their familiarity has been broken. His experience makes me question the border I draw between a thing and my feelings about it. I tend to imagine the world arriving first, solid and complete, and emotion being added afterwards. Yet the robe I remember is already warm. I cannot recover a neutral version of it.

Memory complicates this further. The classroom will continue to feel saturated and dark after I leave school, sometimes subject to the light through the windows. Meanwhile, the table in my head will be exposed to other conditions. Distance. Affection. Whatever kind of day I'm having when I remember it. There may eventually be very little resemblance between my memory and the classroom at some point.

I take photographs. I write down colours. I buy something butter yellow with a vague expectation that it will improve the quality of being me on a Tuesday. I know how absurd this sounds, but a feeling is difficult to approach and a jumper has sleeves. It offers instructions. Put this on. stand in the light. For a moment, the distance between the person I am and the person I imagine being seems no greater than the thickness of the fabric. Perhaps this is part of what consumption promises; an inward change with an outward procedure. I can complete the purchase even when I cannot explain the longing.

Art asks something more uncertain of me. I can own an image without attending to it. I can stand in front of a painting and remain occupied by the thought of what I am going to do afterwards. The Seagram Murals might have become part of an expensive evening's surroundings, my window became part of the architecture of getting somewhere else. Neither beauty nor proximity guarantees an encounter. I would like attention to be a possession too, something I could acquire and then reliably keep. Instead I notice, forget to notice, notice again. I read a sentence twice because the first time my eye arrived without me.

Soon I will leave school, and I am unsure how to inhabit these last months without turning them prematurely into memories. I want the next part of my life. I also want this one to remain available. Some days growing up feels like being asked to love a place sufficiently to leave it, without mistaking leaving for a failure of love. Across the Harkness table, somebody is still speaking. I will have to decide whether to listen or to think about how much I will miss listening.

I came back to this window, one day I looked up and there it was, old glass admitting new light. the yellow falls differently according to the hour. Beyond it, the day continues with all its colours touching. I had passed beneath this small abundance for years. Now I am trying to write it down, although the light will not keep still, and I am beginning to think that this, too, belongs in the description.